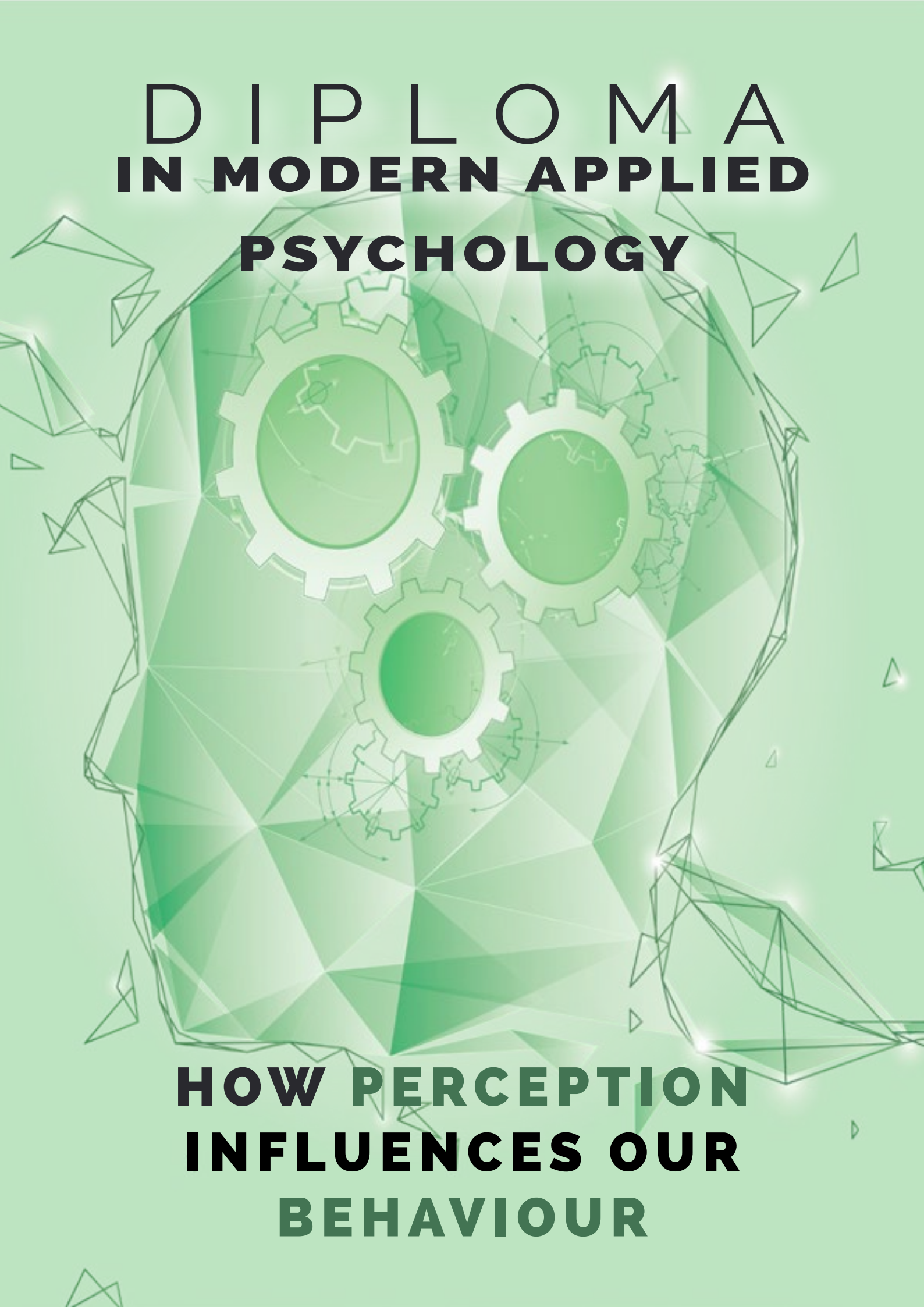


The background is a light green color with a complex, abstract design. A large, semi-transparent wireframe skull is centered on the page. Inside the skull, there are three interlocking gears of different sizes. The gears are white with green outlines and are set against a background of green triangles and lines that form a low-poly, crystalline structure. The overall aesthetic is modern and technological.

DIPLOMA IN MODERN APPLIED PSYCHOLOGY

HOW PERCEPTION INFLUENCES OUR BEHAVIOUR

HOW **PERCEPTION** INFLUENCES BEHAVIOUR

The school of behavioural psychology is based on the principles of cause and effect (i.e there are a stimulus and response going on at all times). This school invests more in the concept of nurture over nature; they believe all behaviour is learned rather than innate and is, therefore, capable of being unlearned and adjusted according to will.

John Watson was a monumental figure in the field of classical conditioning. He wanted to know whether or not fear could be a learned behavioural response, so he conducted an experiment which he called 'The Little Albert Experiment'. It was an experiment which would never be allowed today, not only because it crossed many ethical boundaries, but also because it lacked scientific merit (having only one subject and no control subject). Little Albert was a 9-month-old child who was tested on his reactions to different stimuli.

Albert was shown a white rat, a rabbit, a monkey and various different masks. He showed no fear of any of these stimuli. However, Watson introduced a new stimulus when he struck a hammer against a steel bar behind the child's head causing Little Albert to burst into tears.

When Little Albert was just over 11 months old, they presented him with a white rat, and seconds later the hammer was again struck against the steel bar. This was repeated seven times over the next seven weeks, and every time Little Albert burst into tears. By this stage, Little Albert only had to see the rat, and he immediately showed every sign of fear and would cry whether or not the hammer was hit against the steel bar. He would attempt to crawl away.

Furthermore, Watson discovered that Albert developed phobias of objects which shared similar characteristics with the rat including their family dog, cotton wool, a fur coat and a Santa Claus mask. This process is known as generalisation. Watson had proven that classical conditioning could be used to create phobias.

Aversion therapy is a psychological practice formulated, again, through classical conditioning principles. The intention of this therapy was to prevent and cure 'socially unacceptable behaviour'. The client undergoing the therapy is asked to engage in the behaviour they're wishing to overcome whilst they are exposed to unpleasant stimuli such as unpleasant smells, tastes or mild electric shocks. Despite its dark and morally corrupt origins and questionable ethical practice and dubious results, aversion therapy is still used today for habits and addictions such as smoking, alcoholism, drug addiction, gambling and violence.

In 1971, psychologist Dr Zimbardo used classical conditioning to find out what would happen if good people were situated within bad environments in order to understand cruel behaviour in general. The **Stanford Prison Experiment** aimed to discover if people were born bad or whether people conformed to society and environments they were situated. Dr Zimbardo placed a group of twenty-four mature, mentally stable volunteers into a basement at the Stanford University psychology building which he had converted into a mock prison. Each person was randomly assigned



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the role of prisoner or guard and was subsequently treated according to the role they represented. The prisoners were demeaned and referred to by number only whilst the guards were given dignified clothing and allowed to do to the prisoners whatever they deemed necessary to maintain the peace (excluding violence).

Surprisingly, each group slowly began to conform to their roles. Prisoners took prison rules very seriously and snitched on those who didn't. The guards taunted and insulted the prisoners and gave them boring or difficult tasks to do as punishment. By the second day, the prisoners launched a rebellion against the guards, but the guards retaliated by using a fire extinguisher against the prisoners before stripping them naked and removing their neds from their cells. The experiment was supposed to last a fortnight, but due to the emotional breakdowns the prisoners endured, Dr Zimbardo terminated the experiment after just six days.

The **Monster Study** of 1939 was carried out by 'speech therapist' Wendell Johnson who believed speech experiments were a behaviour. He took twenty-two orphans from a local orphanage and studied their speech. Half the group were given positive speech therapy whilst the other half were subjected to negative speech therapy, in which they were belittled and mocked for speech (despite not having any speech impediments at all). The majority of those exposed to negative speech therapy were so traumatised by the experiment that they developed life-long stuttering and became more withdrawn and under-confident in their speech.

How does our perception influence our behaviour?

Most of us believe our reactions are justifiable and understandable responses to the world around us. We turn on our computers, we can become saddened, angered and frustrated with the stories on our newsfeeds; if a pedestrian suddenly steps out in front of our car, we blast our horn in both fright and frustration; or, if our flight gets delayed by seven hours, we may become irate, defeated or disappointed.

These examples are objectively true: there was another murder in the news, someone did step in front of your car and your flight did get delayed. There's no room for debate, contemplation or critical analysis of the legitimacy of these examples. Yet, despite the objectivity of their reality, people respond to these events differently.

The varied and contrasting responses to certain events can be quite disturbing to many people. Twitter is a perfect platform for showcasing this kind of behaviour. For every trending news article, there is a collective of people who are traumatised as well as a collective of people who find it hilarious and proceed to mock or even celebrate the news.

The reason why everyone responds differently to the same objective truths is that people's responses are driven more by their perceptions than reality itself. In order to positively influence other people, we must be aware of the role our perceptions play in our lives and our natural inclination to sometimes misinterpret information based on our personal cognitive biases.

Reacting and responding in accordance with our perceptions means that our focus isn't primarily on what we're looking at, but rather, where we're looking from. It's easy,



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therefore, to get caught up in our perspectives; our understanding of reality becomes skewed by our personal thoughts, beliefs and feelings before we even have the chance to consider all the possible circumstances of our external environment.

When we allow our perceptions to tell us inaccurate stories about external stimuli, we can often respond in inappropriate or unjustified ways without even recognising our responses as such.

QUESTIONS FOR SELF-REFLECTION:

1. From your perspective, what would you say are the main assumptions of the behavioural school of psychological thought and why are they relevant to you at this stage of your learning and development?
2. How has the process of classical conditioning been applied to your life?
3. From experience, in what areas of your life have you learned to be scared?
4. What effect has negative reinforcement had on your behaviour?
5. What effect has negative reinforcement had on your confidence and self-esteem?



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6. What strategy have you not yet learned which will allow you to start making positive changes in your life?

7. How has a form of classical or operative conditioning influenced your willingness to learn this strategy to make these changes in your life?

